University of Jena
Department of English and American Studies
Winter 2016-17

Daniel Jach
Ernst-Abbe-Platz 8, 607, Wednesday 11-12 a.m.
03641-944545, daniel.jach@uni-jena.de

Second Language Acquisition

BA.AA.SW08
Tuesday, 10 - 12 am
Carl-Zeiß-Straße 3, SR 128
5 ECTS

Seminar Description

> *Hardly one besides the father, the head of the family spoke German. Nevertheless, they were all friendly smiling at me and motioned me in their house. I was offered a seat and Turkish food and drink specialties. The children sat to my feet, listened to me talking German as if I was telling them the most thrilling and entertaining fairy-tale they had ever listened to.*
>
> (ICLE-AUG-0066.1)
>
> (An adult native user of German writes in English about talking in German to child native users of Turkish at their family's place.)

In this seminar, we will be concerned with the processes of acquiring a language in addition to one's native language. As the quote above illustrates, second language acquisition (SLA) is an extremely complex object of investigation. Therefore, we will cover not all but only selected parts of this highly diverse debate. In particular, we will address phenomena which highlight the dynamic, systemic and usage-based nature of SLA. This way, we will learn about the cognitive processes underlying not only SLA but language learning in general. Towards the end of the semester, the seminar will introduce methodological basics of SLA research and we will attempt to conduct some modest-sized empirical studies in preparation for the seminar papers. A final note: Even though SLA research is related to language pedagogy and cross-cultural communication studies, we will not explicitly address them. The seminar rather intends to outline the psycholinguistic background in which future teachers might ground their teaching methods and didactic decisions.

Requirements, weekly preparations and grading system

Your final grade will depend on the seminar paper only (submission deadlines 04-07-2017 and 05-30-2017). Moreover, to be admitted to the seminar paper, a visible commitment to the seminar (continual and active participation, etc.) and weekly preparation in the form of readings and accompanying homework will be required.

The course management system

You find readings and materials on the online platform of our department, WORDWISE. Important information on the organisation of the course will also be distributed via WORDWISE (to your email address). Please enroll in this seminar on WORDWISE (the password was announced in class) and stay updated.

Date	Topic	Preparatory reading	Homework
10-18-2016	Introduction		
10-25-2016	Theoretical positions in SLA	Mitchell et al. (2013), ch. 1	
	Dynamic system aspects of SLA		Send me a question (50-100 signs) about one paper from each of the four key topics. Write what troubled you about the paper, what you thought was particular good/bad, etc. Altogether, you need to write four questions. Some of your questions will be discussed in class. The questions are due on Sundays before class.
11-01-2016	Language as an ever-changing system: language attrition	Hansen and Chen (2001)	
11-08-2016	Language and cognition in interaction: linguistic relativity	Stutterheim and Carroll (2006)	
	Multilingual minds		
11-15-2016	First language effects on second language: sentence acceptability	Hoffmann (2013)	
11-22-2016	First language effects on second language: sentence parsing	Dussias and Sagarra (2007)	
	Developing systems		
11-29-2016	Input effects on second language learning: frequency	Ellis et al. (2008)	
12-06-2016	Input effects on second language learning: recency	McDonough and Mackey (2008)	
	The learner and the other		
12-13-2016	The role of learner characteristics: working memory	Newport (1990)	
12-20-2016	The role of feedback and instructions	Mackey (2006)	
Break			
	SLA explored		
01-03-2017	Methods in SLA research	Mackey and Gass (2005), ch. 3	
01-10-2017	Design of SLA research		Data collection
01-17-2017	Basic statistics in SLA research		Data analysis
01-24-2017	Presentation and discussion of data		
01-31-2017	On writing a seminar paper and conclusion	Schmidtke-Bode (ms)	

References

Dussias, Paola E. and Nuria Sagarra (2007). "The effect of exposure on syntactic parsing in Spanish–English bilinguals". In: *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition* 10.1, pp. 101–116.

Ellis, Nick C., Rita Simpson-Vlach, and Carson Maynard (2008). "Formulaic Language in Native and Second language Speakers: Psycholinguistic, Corpus Linguistics, and TESOL". In: *TESOL Quarterly* 42.3, pp. 375–396.

Hansen, Lynne and Yung-Lin Chen (2001). "What counts in the acquisition and attrition of numeral classifiers". In: *JALT Journal* 23.1, pp. 83–100.

Hoffmann, Thomas (2013). "Obtaining introspective acceptability judgements". In: *Research Methods in Language Variation and Change*. Ed. by M. Krug and J. Schlüter. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 99–118.

Mackey, Alison (2006). "Feedback, noticing and instructed second language learning". In: *Applied linguistics* 27.3, pp. 405–430.

Mackey, Alison and Susan M. Gass (2005). *Second language research: Methodology and design*. Routledge.

McDonough, Kim and Alison Mackey (2008). "Syntactic priming and ESL question development". In: *Studies in Second Language Acquisition* 30.1, pp. 31–47.

Mitchell, Rosamond, Florence Myles, and Emma Marsden (2013). *Second language learning theories*. Routledge.

Newport, Elissa L. (1990). "Maturational constraints on language learning". In: *Cognitive science* 14.1, pp. 11–28.

Schmidtke-Bode, Karsten (ms). "Practical Guidelines for Writing a Paper in Linguistics". online. Jena.

Stutterheim, Christiane von and Mary Carroll (2006). "The impact of grammatical temporal categories on ultimate attainment in L2 learning". In: *Educating for advanced foreign language capacities: Constructs, curriculum, instruction, assessment*. Ed. by Heather D. Weger-Guntharp and Katherine A. Sprang. Georgetown University Press, pp. 40–53.

Note: I reserve the right to alter this syllabus (dates, readings, assignments, et. al.) during the semester when I deem it necessary.